



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta

Sub-registrars appointed across 39 subdivisions

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi government has appointed sub-registrars across all 39 subdivisions through a technology-based randomisation process for the first time, the Chief Minister's Office said on Friday.

“For the first time, the Delhi government has adopted an information technology-based randomisation process for the posting of sub-registrars. The objective is to complete the posting process through a clear, transparent and fair system,” an official statement said.

Airport waterlogged, flights affected as rain lashes Delhi

Commuters wade through flooded underpasses near the airport to reach on time; Palam receives heaviest rainfall in city — 72.2 mm in 3 hours; waterlogging, traffic snarls reported across Capital

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Heavy afternoon showers led to waterlogging in many parts of the city and disrupted traffic movement.

At the Indira Gandhi International (IGI) Airport, passengers were seen wading through stagnant water, even as commuters were seen navigating through flooded underpasses near the airport to reach on time. The downpour also caused flight delays and diversions.

“Delhi Airport witnessed heavy rainfall this afternoon; as a result, the approach road and forecourt areas experienced water accumulation. The accumulated water was cleared within some time,” read a post from the Delhi airport's official X handle.

In a subsequent release, the airport operator stat-



Inundated: Passengers at IGI Airport on Friday afternoon; waterlogged stretch near the Yamuna Bazar underpass. ANI/ SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA



ed, “The inclement weather also impacted flight operations, which led to the delays and diversion of some flights. Our on-ground teams are diligently working with all stakeholders to ensure a seamless and efficient passenger experience.”

A Public Works Department official said, “We deployed pumps to clear out

floodwaters. The catchment area of the underpass [near Terminal I] is big, and due to flooding in Mehrauli, waterlogging was reported in the tunnel, which was cleared later.”

As per the India Meteorological Department, Palam received 72.2 mm of rainfall in the three hours between 2.30 p.m. and 5.30 p.m., the highest

among the city's weather stations, followed by 34.6 mm at Lodhi Road, 32.6 mm at Safdarjung (Delhi's representative weather station), 20 mm at the Ridge and 12 mm at Ayanagar.

Waterlogging and traffic snarls were reported from Sadar Bazar, Kamla Nagar, ITO, Mahipalpur, Dwarka, Subroto Park, Saket, Hamdard, Patparganj and C.P.

Seeing IPS officers beating protesters very distressing, says Justice Bhuyan

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Supreme Court judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan on Friday expressed concern over the alleged assault of protesters by police personnel during the recent youth-led protests at Jantar Mantar, saying the detachment expected of police officers appears to be disappearing and terming it a “matter of grave concern”.

Speaking at the launch of retired Indian Police Service officer Yashovardhan Azad's book ‘Policing the Republic’, Justice Bhuyan said, “All of us are dismayed when we see young officers of the Indian Police Service personally going and assaulting protesters. This is something very, very distressing to observe.”

Congress MP P. Chidambaram and former Maharashtra police chief D. Sivanandhan were among those present at the event.

“For most common people, a policeman on the street wearing a whistle and a lathi represents the power and authority of the

‘2,873 hits via facial scans at Jantar Mantar under check’

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Verification of 2,873 people who were *prima facie* identified as having criminal antecedents through the facial recognition system at the Jantar Mantar protests is under way, a senior police officer said on Friday. The officer added that field visits are being

conducted to verify whether the 2,873 names generated by their facial recognition system were at the protest site between July 20 and 26. Another officer said they are reaching out to jail authorities to establish whether any of the flagged individuals were in prison or out on bail or parole during the six-day period.

state. When they feel wronged, they seek the help of the police. It is, therefore, of utmost importance that the police force maintains its credibility,” said the apex court judge.

Following Constitution

He added, “It can do so only by strictly adhering to the Constitution, by functioning as a truly professional force, acting impartially, displaying courage

and conviction, and adhering to secular principles.”

Question of rights

Invoking the Supreme Court's judgment in the 1997 *D.K. Basu v. State of West Bengal* case, he said the court had posed a fundamental question — does a citizen shed his fundamental rights the moment he is arrested? “The answer indeed has to be an emphatic no,” he said.

Journalists to move HC seeking police assault footage

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

The two women journalists, who accused Delhi Police of assaulting them inside the Saket police station, said on Friday they would move the Delhi High Court seeking directions to release CCTV footage of the incident.

Speaking at a press conference, Shaheen Khan, who works with 4PM News Network, and independent journalist Nafeesa Khan al-

leged they were forcibly taken to the police station on Thursday while they were covering an event attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

They said they were beaten up in a closed room by a plain-clothes woman police officer.

In a representation submitted to the President of India, Sanjay Sharma, Editor of 4PM News Network, a digital news platform, sought an independent in-

The two women journalists were not provided with a memo of the ‘arrest or the grounds for their detention’, said the Editor of 4PM News Network

quiry into the incident and action against the police personnel involved.

“The two journalists were engaged in newsgathering near Max Hospital in

Saket around 11.30 a.m. on September 3. They were recording visuals and commentary on cleaning work being carried out in the area ahead of an expected VVIP visit by the Union Home Minister. Police personnel arrived at the spot and forcibly took the two journalists away,” he alleged.

Mr. Sharma also alleged that the two women journalists were subjected to derogatory, communal and casteist remarks, in-

cluding comments targeting Ms. Khan's religious identity.

The two journalists were not provided with a memo of the “arrest or the grounds for their detention”, he said.

The Editor of the digital platform also sought an independent and time-bound inquiry into the incident and requested that the Station House Officer of Saket police station be removed or suspended pending the inquiry.

BRICS Summit: command centre set for launch today

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The New Delhi Municipal Council will launch a 24x7 command centre on Saturday, which will operate till September 14 to monitor civic services and ground-level issues during the two-day BRICS Summit starting on September 12, an official said on Friday.

Nodal officers from the agencies concerned, including Delhi Police and the Central Public Works Department, will be deputed round the clock at the centre located in Palika Kendra, the official added.

Meanwhile, a senior officer said traffic movement is likely to be affected in central, south and south-



Workers painting a sidewalk near Bharat Mandapam on Friday. SHASHI SHEKHAR KASHYAP

west Delhi for four days from September 10. Nearly 4,800 traffic personnel will be deployed to manage the movement of delegates.

Court rejects B&B owner's bail petition

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

A Delhi court has rejected the interim bail plea filed by the owner of Flourish Stay, a bed-and-breakfast (B&B) facility where a fire killed 23 people on June 3.

Additional Sessions Judge Samar Vishal was hearing Lovkesh Bajaj's plea on Wednesday seeking four weeks interim bail on medical grounds, during which he said the medical exigency cited by the accused had already been addressed through surgery at Ram Manohar Hospital. The court also said a person in judicial custody is entitled to adequate treatment and that cannot be ignored.

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EOI SCHEDULE.

1.	EOI Reference No. BECC/2026-27/SE0128
2.	Date of Commencement of Download of EOI Document from KPP website http://kppp.karnataka.gov.in from 04-09-2026
3.	Tender Inviting Authority : Assistant Director (Animal Husbandry), BECC
4.	Tender Accepting Authority : Commissioner, BECC
5.	Estimated amount of tender : ₹. 1,80,00,000/-
6.	Last Date and Time for uploading Online Queries in Karnataka Public Procurement Portal upto 07-09-2026 5:00 pm
7.	Date and Time of Pre-bid Meeting: 07-09-2026 at 2:30 pm at the following venue: Office of the AD(AH), Ground floor, KR Puram, BECC Sub-Division Office, KR Puram, Bengaluru-560036.
8.	Last Date and Time for uploading of EOI in KPP Portal upto 15-09-2026 5:00 pm
9.	Date and Time of Opening of EOI in KPP Portal upto 16-09-2026 5:10 pm
10.	Place of Opening of EOI Online at KPP portal
11.	Address for Communication : AD(AH), Ground floor, KR Puram, BECC Sub-Division Office, KR Puram, Bengaluru-560036, Phone: 8296184712 Email: adahkcp01@gmail.com

Sd/- Assistant Director (Animal Husbandry), GBA, BECC

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU

0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Kuldeep Kumar S/O Banarsi Dass R/O Preet Nagar, Jammu is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. 41/2012 U/S 341/382/323/34 RPC, of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded. It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name	: Kuldeep Kumar
S/O	: Banarsi Dass
Address	: Preet Nagar, Jammu
Age	: 30-35 Years

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu	: 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D	: sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu	: 0191-2605949
4. SP City South	: 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East	: 01912433778
6. P/S Bahu Fort	: 0191-2475133

Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J- 9427/26

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

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DEATH

OBITUARY



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Giri vide affidavit dated 23-02-
2026 at Raurkela

PUBLIC NOTICE

A Son of Jharkhand to Represent
a Sensitive Case Before the
Honourable Supreme Court

An incident occurred on 3rd July
2013 in Kathikund Police Station
jurisdiction, Dumka District,
Jharkhand. While the Superintend-
ent of Police (SP) of Dumka was
returning from a meeting with DIG
Pakur, indiscriminate firing broke
out, resulting in the tragic deaths of
the Dumka SP and six police
personnel. Advocate Aman Raj
will be representing the innocent
prisoners in this case.

AMAN RAJ
Advocate
Enrolment No. JH/490/2025
Civil Court Giridih (PIN: 815301)
High Court Ranchi, Jharkhand.

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5th & 12th SEPTEMBER

Contact : 8800660380

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU

0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SDPO City East, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Azad Ali S/O Sayed Ali R/O Batwala P/S Sanjdgargh, District Gopal Gang Bihar is evading his arrest / wanted in case FIR No. 243/2018 U/S 382 RPC, of P/S Bahu Fort, Jammu. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded. It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers

Description Roll :-

Name	: Azad Ali
S/O	: Sayed Ali
Address	: Batwala P/S Sanjdgargh, District Gopal Gang Bihar
Age	: 30-35 Years

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu	: 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D	: sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu	: 0191-2605949
4. SP City South	: 0191-2430002
5. SDPO City East	: 01912433778
6. P/S Bahu Fort	: 0191-2475133

Sr. Superintendent of Police Jammu

DIP/J- 9425/26

JAMMU AND KASHMIR POLICE

DISTRICT POLICE HEADQUARTERS JAMMU

0191-2561578 (O), 0191-254780 (F), email-sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in

Hue and Cry Notice Rule No. 712/191

SHO P/S Bakshi Nagar, Jammu has intimated that accused person namely Darshan Kumar S/O Basu Ram R/O 319 Resham Ghar Colony, Jammu is evading his arrest/wanted in case FIR No. 170/2021 U/S 457/80/411 RPC of P/S Bakshi Nagar, Jammu, since the commission of crime. Despite repeated raids/efforts the accused could not be traced/still absconded. It is therefore requested that Hue and Cry Notice of above mentioned accused is being published for the information of Police establishments / Public in general having any clue related to the whereabouts / present location of above named accused, kindly communicate the same on the below mentioned contact / Telephone numbers.

Description Roll :-

Name	: Darshan Kumar
S/O	: Basu Ram
Address	: 319 Resham Ghar Colony, Jammu
Height	: 5' 09"
Complexion	: Wheatish
Eyes	: Black

Contacts/Telephone Numbers:-

1. DPO, Jammu	: 0191-2547807, 0191-2561578
2. SSP Jammu Mail I.D	: sspjammu@jkpolice.gov.in
3. PCR Jammu	: 0191-2605949
4. SP City North	: 0191-2547038
5. SDPO City West	: 0191-2580251
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MARUTI SUZUKI

NEXA

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INBRIEF



Mayawati asks Centre to clear scepticism over GDP figures

Bahujan Samaj Party chief Mayawati on Friday urged the Centre to address doubts over credibility of the first-quarter GDP figures. She said India's 7.8% growth in the April-June quarter had drawn scepticism, with people "suffering from the blows of hyper-inflation, immense poverty, and unemployment" wondering whom to trust. In a post on X, Ms. Mayawati said that while the government's "sky-high claims" on economic growth would be welcome if they reflected reality, "if these are fudged figures, it is certainly a cause for concern". PTI

Chugh seeks NHRC probe over Sikh youth's 'custodial torture'

BJP Rajya Sabha MP Tarun Chugh on Friday urged the National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) to take suo motu cognisance of the alleged custodial torture of a Sikh youth who waved a black flag at a programme of Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann. Chugh requested the human rights body to send an independent fact-finding team to the village where the incident took place and the police station concerned, and direct the registration of an FIR against the officers involved, including the Deputy Superintendent of Police. He also sought high-level security and medical assistance for the victim and his family. PTI

Mumbai sees 612% rise in H1N1 cases this monsoon

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Mumbai has seen a surge in H1N1 (swine flu) cases over the last three months, as the number of cases have jumped to 441 this year from 62 during same period last year. This marks a 612% rise, while for malaria the cases have seen a 20% rise.

According to Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC)'s monsoon data for June, July, and August, 441 cases of H1N1, and 4,485 malaria cases were recorded between June and August as compared to 3,733 last year.

To curb the surge of swine flu, BMC has been screening suspected H1N1 patients, and prescribing Oseltamivir. Further, surveys are being conducted in the affected regions, where the H1N1 positive cases have been located.

Bihar govt. reiterates income rule for OBC creamy layer status

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Bihar government has reiterated that State officials cannot include parents' salaries and agricultural income while determining the creamy layer status of Other Backward Classes (OBC) candidates, saying existing guidelines issued by both the Centre and the State clearly prohibit it.

In an order dated September 1, the General Administration Department (GAD) referred to the Department of Personnel and Training's (DoPT) 1993 principal guidelines governing the creamy layer exclusion process, as well as orders issued by the State government over the years. The order, addressed to all District Magistrates, reiterated all earlier directions, particularly those governing the appli-

cation of the income test. It acknowledged reports that the process was not being followed in full and called for strict adherence to the clarified provisions.

The clarification comes against the backdrop of the Union government approaching the Supreme Court last week to seek clarity on how the income test should be applied, particularly in light of the *Rohith Nathan* judgment on March 11, which recognised that the DoPT had been applying the income test differently across categories of OBC candidates.

The Supreme Court noted that income from parents' salaries alone was used to exclude some OBC candidates from reservation without first determining whether their parents' posts were equivalent to government positions covered under the creamy layer criteria.

TVK to hold second meeting with post-poll allies on Sept. 9

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

The ruling TVK is planning to hold a second meeting with its post-poll alliance partners in Chennai on September 9, a day after the conclusion of the Budget Session of the Assembly, to discuss formalisation of the present arrangement as a political alliance.

The first meeting of the TVK's post-poll partners was held at a private hotel in Chennai on July 1. Barring the two Left parties, top leaders of all other post-poll partners of the TVK, including the Congress, the IUML, the MDMK, and the VCK, held discussions with TVK president and Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay.

During the first round of discussions, it was decided to work on forming a coordination committee to steer the formation of alliance, drafting of a common minimum pro-



Ministers N. Anand, Aadhav Arjuna and C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar with CPI(M) T.N. secretary P. Shanmugam on Friday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

gramme, and deciding on a name for the formation during the second meeting. Against this backdrop, the TVK has planned to host the second meeting with its post-poll partners on September 9. Mr. Vijay is expected to take part in the meeting and hold discussion with the leaders of the post-poll allies. The TVK started reaching out to the leaders of the friendly parties on Friday.

TVK general secretary and Minister for Water Resources N. Anand, along

with other senior party leaders and Ministers, including Aadhav Arjuna, C.T.R. Nirmal Kumar and Rajmohan, met CPI(M) state secretary P. Shanmugam, CPI state secretary M. Veerapandian and MDMK general secretary Vaiko to extend a formal invitation.

Mr. Kumar said it was a courtesy call on Mr. Shanmugam. Mr. Veerapandian said the Ministers held a meeting with CPI leaders on the future course of action of the Left parties in Tamil Nadu politics.

Toxic pond in Haryana village puts rare turtles at risk

Ashok Kumar
GURUGRAM

For years, the pond at Kajalheri village in Haryana's Fatehabad was a safe haven for hundreds of rare turtles. Today, the same waters are forcing them to flee for their lives.

The Shri Guru Gorakhnath Community Reserve, notified by the Haryana government in 2019, is home to an estimated 150-200 Indian softshell, red-crowned roofed and Indian peacock turtles. But the sanctuary has allegedly turned into a toxic habitat because of untreated sewage and neglect by the authorities.

The species found here enjoy the highest level of statutory protection under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, on a par with tigers and rhinoceroses. They are also listed as



The reserve is home to an estimated 150-200 softshell, red-crowned roofed and Indian peacock turtles. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

threatened species on the IUCN Red List.

Critical issues

Environmentalists said the contaminated water is causing skin lesions, fungal infections and blindness among softshell turtles. With the pond becoming increasingly foul and polluted, the turtles have begun leaving the reserve and crossing agricultural fields and roads in search

of cleaner water. Many have allegedly been crushed by vehicles while attempting to reach the nearby Kishangarh canal.

Wildlife conservationist Vaishali Rana has sought the registration of a criminal case under the Wildlife (Protection) Act against wildlife officials, Kajalheri panchayat functionaries and members of the reserve management committee. She has accused

them of allowing deliberate sewage discharge into the turtle habitat and failing to comply with directions issued by the Gurugram Chief Conservator of Forest (Wildlife) following an inspection in January.

The problem does not end with polluted water. In the absence of proper fencing, stray dogs reportedly enter the reserve and dig up turtle nests to eat the eggs, while cattle brought into the pond trample nesting banks and destroy eggs. The turtles are also at risk of being crushed.

A senior wildlife official acknowledged the problems but attributed the delay in remedial measures to a shortage of funds. The department's action plan includes diverting sewage away from the pond, erecting fencing and creating raised mounds where turtles can safely lay

their eggs. The official said the work would begin after the monsoon once funds are released.

Official apathy

The locals, meanwhile, allege that the crisis is the result of official apathy rather than a lack of resources.

Satpal Kajal, a resident, alleged that funds allocated earlier were diverted to other projects because of a nexus between the panchayat and wildlife officials. He said chemical-laden waste from the village had polluted the pond, forcing the turtles towards the canal. "There is enough land to create a separate pond to divert the toxic waste," he said, adding that complaints had also been made to then Wildlife Minister Kanwar Pal Gujar during the previous government, but no action followed.

Tie-up buzz grows as Shah meets Tripura CM, Tipra Motha leader

Syed Sajjad Ali
AGARTALA

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday met Tripura Chief Minister Manik Saha and Tipra Motha Party founder Pradyot Kishore Manikya in New Delhi ahead of the September 28 elections to 587 village committees under the Tripura Tribal Areas Autonomous District Council (TTAADC), with sources indicating progress towards an alliance between the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and the regional party.

Mr. Saha, Mr. Manikya and Tipra Motha leaders Brishaketu Debbarma and Ranjit Debbarma reached New Delhi on Thursday for talks at various levels. In a brief statement on social media, Mr. Saha said, "We

Assam Cong. seeks EC probe into ex-Nagaon DC's 'BJP candidature'

Press Trust of India
GUWAHATI



The Assam unit of the Congress on Friday sought the intervention of the Election Commission (EC) of India over reports that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) was likely to field former Nagaon deputy commissioner Devasish Sharma in the Nagaon Lok Sabha byelection.

The Congress contended that questions would be raised over the neutrality of the byelection as Mr. Sharma had directly handled "sensitive aspects" of the district till recently.

However, State BJP spokesperson Kamal Medhi said, "Our party has a set system of selecting candidates for any election. One has to meet the requisite criteria for candidature. Moreover, Mr. Sharma has not joined the BJP yet."

Our party has a set system of selecting candidates for any election. Moreover, Devasish Sharma has not joined the BJP yet

KAMAL MEDHI
Assam BJP spokesperson

The Congress contended that questions would be raised over the neutrality of the byelection as Mr. Sharma had directly handled "sensitive aspects" of the district till recently.

However, State BJP spokesperson Kamal Medhi said, "Our party has a set system of selecting candidates for any election. One has to meet the requisite criteria for candidature. Moreover, Mr. Sharma has not joined the BJP yet."

The Congress, nevertheless, sought an independent, time-bound inquiry into the tenure of Sharma, who took voluntary retirement recently, including into allegations of financial irregularities in the allocation of gram panchayat funds. While State Congress president Gaurav Gogoi aired his apprehensions on social media, the

party's Dhubri MP Rakibul Hussain wrote to the EC on the issue.

"The @ECISVEEP must urgently intervene in the Nagaon Lok Sabha bye-election in Assam. There are serious questions arising from the resignation of the Nagaon DC Shri Devasish Sharma and his alleged attempt to contest the forthcoming bye-election from the BJP," Mr. Gogoi said in a social media post.

The Nagaon byelection has been necessitated following the resignation of incumbent two-term MP Pradyut Bordoloi, who quit the Congress to join the BJP just ahead of the Assam Assembly polls in April. He is now the MLA of the Dispur constituency.

Mr. Gogoi said over the past few months, Mr. Sharma had handled several aspects of the electoral process.

Bihar's 'dharti pakad', who contested nearly 300 polls, dies at 97

Press Trust of India
BHAGALPUR



Nagarmal Bajoria, a Bihar businessman known for contesting nearly 300 elections, has died at 97, his family said on Friday.

According to the family, the Bhagalpur resident, who boasted of having challenged former Prime Ministers Indira Gandhi and Rajiv Gandhi on their home turfs of Rae Bareilly and Amethi, respectively, breathed his last at a hospital in Patna on Thursday following a prolonged illness. His body was brought to Bhagalpur, where his last rites were performed on Friday. Hailing from western Punjab, which now falls in Pakistan, Bajoria was among the millions of refugees who fled their homes during the horrific communal violence that marked the Partition.

After settling in the east-

Nagarmal Bajoria breathed his last at a hospital in Patna on Thursday following a prolonged illness. FILE PHOTO

ern Bihar town, which in those days was known for its thriving textile industry, Bajoria is said to have decided to make himself count in the nascent republic by becoming the proverbial perennial candidate, thereby earning the epithet "*dharti pakad*".

"He contested close to 300 elections, insisting every time that he wanted to raise public awareness that polls were about the people and not power," said Gaurav, a grandson of Bajoria.



Warning on warming

India must shed its victim mindset while acting on climate change

The United Nations Environment Programme’s report, Limiting Overshoot, is a reminder that breaching the 1.5°C global warming limit would bring irreversible losses that adaptation cannot undo. Were all countries to deliver on their climate pledges today, the globe is still poised to heat 1.8°C and on current policies, 2.6°C. Given that the limit has already been breached – and, with the ongoing heating in the central equatorial Pacific expected to burgeon into one of the strongest El Niños in recent history, likely again in 2027 – the report is an acceptance of the scientific reality that we are in a 1.5°C world, while resisting the conclusion that nothing more can be done. The authors describe an “overshoot, peak and decline” pathway under which average global temperatures rise above 1.5°C but countries collectively hold the peak as low as possible and then bring them back below the limit by the end of the century. Neutralising the heating effect of even a tenth of a degree, the report argues, is far harder than preventing that rise in the first place. This in itself is nothing new. What is new is the emphasis on greenhouse gases beyond carbon dioxide. Action on methane, responsible for about 0.5°C of current warming, is considered the most effective way to slow warming in the near-term. Over 155 countries – India is not among them – have joined the Global Methane Pledge to cut anthropogenic methane at least 30% below 2020 levels by 2030.

That absence reflects the familiar tension between reports of this nature, which emphasise mitigation, and major developing economies such as India. They stress that they are already en route to moving away from fossil fuels and, being vulnerable to the impacts of historical stocks of carbon, deserve greater financial support and affordable technology from richer developed countries responsible for the crisis. The latest report unfortunately has little to say on adaptation finance, though there are previous assessments on the topic. With countries set to convene in Türkiye in November for COP31, familiar disagreements are likely to surface – but in the aftermath of the Bhotekoshi disaster in Nepal, India’s position too has been complicated. Nepal’s Foreign Affairs Minister, Shisir Khanal, has said that major industrial emitters such as China, the United States and India must consider the impact of rising temperatures on small countries such as Nepal. For India, this list means that a section of the world – despite India’s position as a victim of climate change with below-world-average per capita emissions – sees it as part of the problem. India must take such perceptions seriously and, rather than ignore the reality of a 1.5°C world, should calibrate its messaging to adapt to it.

Out of neglect bin

The perimenopausal policy will ease access to care for women in midlife

Women’s health care can be accused of being focused entirely on the reproductive age group. Menopause, for instance, is a natural transition phase, but even when its symptoms are severe and debilitating, women seldom have access to health care, and are forced to ‘just endure’. Given the huge care gap that exists here, it is appreciable that Tamil Nadu and Karnataka have taken the step to move ahead with the announcement of a perimenopause/menopause policy. Both the States made the announcement within a short while of each other, in August. The primary benefit, besides retrieving women’s mid-life care from the neglect bin it has been languishing in so far, is that the physical and mental-health needs of women in this stage of life will become part of routine government health care, making access to care easier. Tamil Nadu Health Minister K.G. Arunraj made the announcement of a perimenopausal care policy in the Assembly on August 17. He said the aim was to facilitate early identification of physical and mental health needs of perimenopausal women, with screening, counselling and treatment services through PHCs and higher centres. On August 4, Karnataka Health and Family Welfare Minister U.T. Khader, introduced ‘Ruthu Thare’ as the country’s first dedicated women’s health policy with a strong focus on perimenopause and menopause, at a meeting in Bengaluru. Menopause is the permanent end of menstrual periods and reproductive ability, confirmed after 12 consecutive months without a cycle. It happens when the ovaries naturally slow down and produce lower levels of the hormones oestrogen and progesterone. The transition time, leading up to menopause, is the perimenopausal period which can bring irregular periods and bodily changes over several years. Common symptoms include hot flashes, sleep trouble, extreme mood changes, joint pain, debility and fatigue, and for many women these can be disruptive.

Both States are planning outreach screening and counselling at the community level, women’s-health clinics, district-level well-women screening, and community outreach, besides referrals to district hospitals and government medical colleges. No doubt, this is a progressive measure which will also give legitimacy to the complaints of menopausal women, but the proof of any pudding is in the eating. How effective these policies are will be measured only during implementation. Among the critical points today is that the symptoms of menopause are not treated with adequate seriousness even by the medical community; so, adequate awareness generation among medical professionals and the beneficiaries and their families as well is a must.

For decades, India’s relationship with West Asia operated under a doctrine of deliberate ambiguity and even of some strategic distance. Delhi treated the “Middle East” primarily as an economic hinterland: a critical source of crude oil, a reliable destination for outbound labour, and a vital conduit for remittances. When regional crises flared, Indian foreign policy defaulted to hedging, balancing relations between competing power centres such as Riyadh, Tehran, Tel Aviv, and Abu Dhabi without tying itself to the security obligations of any single capital. Of late, we called that approach “multi-alignment”.

What worked until now

But while India was careful to be friendly to all, it was not too friendly to any, in an effort not to offend any of the various capitals in the mix. The logic was clear: there was much to be gained from all parties in what was widely seen to be a likely West Asian economic renaissance. The region was seen through a macroeconomic vision that highlighted its convenient geographic features, its immense natural resources of oil and gas, massive capital accumulation, and its receptivity to imported labour and skills, of which India has a surplus. In this framing, the global economic centre of gravity was seen as inexorably shifting away from an aging, debt-burdened West toward a highly dynamic Asia, positioning West Asia as the ultimate maritime and terrestrial bridge between a declining West and a rising East.

This defensive and essentially transactional posture served India well in an era when the United States stood as the undisputed guarantor of West Asian security, keeping sea lines of communication open and maintaining regional stability. However, the geopolitical bedrock of West Asia is undergoing a violent structural shift. As Washington recalibrates its global commitments and retreats into an unpredictable “selective engagement” posture, a profound security vacuum has emerged, sparking a scramble among regional states for durable security guarantees. Here, has India been caught napping, continuing a business-as-usual approach that risks early obsolescence?

West Asian capitals no longer view distancing, whether called non-alignment or multi-alignment, as a virtue. They are actively seeking alternative, dependable security partners who can offer more than diplomatic platitudes and routine economic cooperation. This structural reality was highlighted by the signing of the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement, bringing together Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Pakistan into a collective defence arrangement. While framed as a defensive effort to manage shared



Shashi Tharoor

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A changing West Asia requires a more assertive Indian role in pursuing real, hard-power security partnerships

vulnerabilities, the pact signals a broader security realignment. By linking Gulf capital with Turkish defence technology and Pakistani military manpower and skill, the agreement creates a powerful new security architecture right at India’s western maritime doorstep.

A clear signal of change

For New Delhi, the Mecca Agreement is not an isolated diplomatic transaction; it is a clear structural signal that West Asia’s security framework is being fundamentally rewritten, often by actors whose strategic interests directly run counter to India’s own long-term objectives. While India’s strategic silence on this development is understandable, it still begs the question: what next? The growing influence of external powers and hostile regional pacts directly threatens India’s trade routes, energy security, and the welfare of millions of Indian citizens living in the Gulf. Is India going to build its own partnerships, or become irrelevant to the region’s security?

If India continues to rely on legacy diplomatic processes and transactional commerce, it risks being marginalised in a region essential to its national survival. The challenges are formidable. The eruption of hostilities involving Iran demonstrated that modern, highly integrated economic infrastructure remains profoundly fragile when subjected to grey-zone, asymmetric warfare. State-of-the-art port facilities, energy networks, and logistics corridors proved highly vulnerable to low-cost drones, showing that capital-intensive infrastructure cannot fully compensate for localised security vacuums. Hyper-secure economic enclaves will remain perpetually exposed to the spillover effects of surrounding instability in the region. Since the modern Gulf model relies heavily on foreign corporations and expatriate labour, regional stability is intimately tied to global perception. If security risks cross a certain psychological threshold, the talent and capital that flowed in seamlessly can exit just as rapidly. And when narrow naval chokepoints or overland trade routes face active disruption, global supply chains inevitably stall, revealing that these ambitious trade corridors are only as strong as their most unstable geographic link.

Against this critical background, the assumption that trade ties and diaspora diplomacy alone can preserve Indian influence is rapidly unravelling. A region grappling with maritime threats in the Red Sea, drone strikes on critical infrastructure, involvement in conflicts in Iran, Yemen, Sudan, the Strait of Hormuz and now the Bab el-Mandab, requires partners capable of providing tangible security assets.

West Asian powers are hungry for hard-power options such as naval patrols, intelligence sharing, defence-industrial collaboration, and credible counter-terrorism capabilities. If India Delhi-dallies over stepping into such a role, others will fill the void, as Türkiye has already demonstrated in Mecca.

The hard moves India must make

To protect its strategic space, New Delhi must contemplate a decisive doctrine change, evolving from a passive beneficiary of regional stability into an active guarantor of it. This requires moving beyond high-level bilateral visits and economic summits to actively project hard power into the western Indian Ocean and the broader West Asian region. India’s immediate focus must be the rapid expansion of naval and maritime security partnerships across key choke points, including the Strait of Hormuz, the Gulf of Oman and the Gulf of Aden, the waters off the Somali coast and the Bab-el-Mandeb. By embedding its naval footprint more deeply through joint maritime patrols, permanent logistics access arrangements, and interoperable surveillance networks with friendly Gulf states, India can establish itself as a, if not the, premier net security provider in its immediate neighbourhood.

Furthermore, India must leverage its growing defence manufacturing ecosystem to offer West Asian states a reliable alternative for hardware and technology. Collaborative defence ventures, joint military exercises with real operational teeth, and deep intelligence-sharing mechanisms must replace mere procurement discussions. Developing robust bilateral and “minilateral” security frameworks with partners such as the United Arab Emirates or Israel, and separately even with Saudi Arabia, will allow Delhi to build a counterweight against hostile axes without succumbing to rigid Cold-War style alliances. The goal is not to entangle India in foreign quagmires, but to build a strategic deterrence web that safeguards Indian interests and reassures regional allies.

The era of passive presence in West Asia has reached its natural end. The Mecca Agreement serves as a stark reminder that regional security arrangements will coalesce with or without Indian participation. If Delhi wishes to secure its economic destiny, safeguard its energy arteries, and claim its rightful place as a leading global power, it must act with urgency and ambition. Moving decisively beyond routine diplomatic engagement to construct real, hard-power security partnerships in West Asia is no longer just a strategic choice for India. It is an imperative for its national security.

A BIT of a reset, with a wider debate

It has been widely reported that India is revising its model bilateral investment treaty (BIT) and that the revised text will soon be placed before the Union cabinet. The seeds of this were sown when Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said in the Union Budget speech in 2025, that India was considering revamping its 2015 Model BIT. The treaty was adopted as part of a broader appraisal process launched after several foreign investors sued India for BIT breaches. The two key outcomes of this appraisal were the unilateral termination of BITs and the adoption of a new model BIT as the basis to launch new negotiations.

A model that is out of balance

In the last decade or so, India has managed to conclude only a handful of BITs based on its 2015 model. This reveals the many limitations of the 2015 model, which many scholars, including this writer, have repeatedly pointed out. If investment treaties aim to balance the two competing objectives of investment protection (one end of the spectrum) and the state’s right to regulate (the other end), the Indian model BIT tilts heavily towards the latter. This creates doubts among countries that export capital to India about the legal protection afforded to their investments. These doubts are exacerbated by high regulatory risks, not-so-well-developed governance models, and an agonisingly tardy judicial system. As these concerns have grown louder, India has rightly decided to revisit the model, apparently with the objective of pulling the pendulum back towards the centre.

Any process of review of BITs has two core components. The first is on what substantive and procedural changes need to be made to the law; and the second is about what processes need to be followed to ensure the robustness of the outcome. The first aspect has attracted considerable attention, with experts pointing out



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Revising India’s bilateral investment treaty (BIT) requires consultation and stronger democratic accountability

the necessary legal reforms, such as making it easier for foreign investors to use international arbitration for treaty claims, enhancing the substantive protections for foreign investment, and having more investment facilitation measures. However, the second issue has not been deliberated much.

Concerns about democratic deficit

Since international economic treaties, including those on foreign investment, have a conspicuous impact on citizens, it brings into play the all-affected principle in democracy. In other words, whether those affected by, say, an investment treaty should have a right to participate in decision-making. If those affected are not able to participate effectively in decision-making, say, through their elected representatives or other civil society organisations, it raises concerns about ‘democratic deficit’ in the treaty-making process. Originating in debates in Europe, ‘democratic deficit’ refers to the insufficient oversight of technocrats and bureaucracies, or the executive in general, including the political executive, who negotiate and evolve treaty frameworks behind closed doors. The lack of oversight may take many forms, such as a lack of or inadequate parliamentary supervision of the treaty-making process, and an absence of an external consultative process with other stakeholders, including subject-matter experts and civil society organisations.

To overcome the charge of ‘democratic deficit’, many countries, such as the United Kingdom and Australia, mandatorily place the text of the negotiated treaty before ratification on the floor of the Parliament, enabling it to express its views. Specifically, in the context of model BITs, Norway held two rounds of public consultations – in 2008 and 2015 – on an updated draft. Likewise, Colombia released its model BIT for public

consultation. India, too, in March 2015, circulated its draft 2015 model BIT for public comment. This provided an opportunity for the Law Commission of India (LCI) to assemble a team of experts to study the draft model BIT. The LCI, in its 260th report, made recommendations on how to improve the draft model BIT. India finally adopted the revised version in December 2015, though not all of the LCI’s recommended changes were reflected in it.

Have a consultative process

Presumably, the government must have already undertaken widespread internal consultations, i.e., intra-governmental deliberations on the model BIT. As regards external consultation, the following may be considered. First, form a core team of experts, external to the government, who have demonstrated proficiency in international investment law or foreign investment, and engage with them. This would ideally include international lawyers and economists drawn from universities, research institutions and think tanks. This core team could act as the sounding board for the government. Second, invite industry bodies, arbitrators, law firms, and other civil society organisations to offer their views on the model BIT.

Following these first two steps, the third step will be to prepare a draft and place it in the public domain, inviting comments from the public at large, as done in March 2015. In the fourth step, or simultaneously, the draft model BIT should be placed on the floor of Parliament for discussion. The relevant department-related parliamentary committees can also be roped in for the same. Most notably, this consultative process should not be carried out merely as a box-ticking exercise, but as a meaningful activity that upholds the spirit of participatory democracy, which would necessarily include engagement with dissenting views.

New Secretariat in Chennai

The report, “New Secretariat to come up in Chennai at ₹1,200 crore: Vijay” (Front page, September 4), has highlighted three possible sites. Having been involved in the site-selection process in 2003 as tahsildar, Mylapore-Triplicane taluk, I would like to suggest the Madras Race Course as another option. Several sites, including the Government Data Centre, Anna University Campus,

Directorate of Technical Education, Highways Research Station and Anna University’s Taramani Campus, were surveyed at the time. The Madras Race Course could be ideal, given its accessibility, scope for wider road approaches, suitability for VIP visits and convenient access for the public.

S. Dharmarajan, Chennai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



The government middle school in Hirapur, Sehore district, Madhya Pradesh. The school is located in a dilapidated building. It is in the same premises as the village panchayat office and a community centre ground. MEHUL MALPANI

Missing: boundary walls, bathrooms, blackboards

Across north and central India, government school education, especially in rural areas, is a challenge, both in terms of the number of teachers in every school and the state of the building that houses children. Reporters from four States track the state of school education. **Amarnath Tewary, Ashna Butani, Mayank Kumar, and Mehul Malpani** examine teaching quality and infrastructural support

In August 10, Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), said in a video that since Independence, no government has been able to provide students in rural areas with the same facilities as those available to students in urban areas. He pledged to begin checking schools in the district from which he hails, Hingoli in Maharashtra, and request sarpanchs to improve the situation.

“We have constructed a new Parliament and a new residence for the Prime Minister. Why, then, are we not able to construct new schools in our villages? Do we not consider the children of farmers and labourers as the future of our country,” he asked.

Since August 15, the CJP’s ‘School thik karo (reform schools)’ campaign has shone a spotlight on the condition of schools across States, with issues ranging from broken roofs to a lack of washrooms and drinking water. It asked locals to participate in a three-step audit of schools: ‘download a checklist, conduct the audit, and submit and tag us’. The checklist includes questions about whether the school has drinking water, boundary walls, wash rooms, and midday meals.

Bihar
At Dumri Kewat Tola primary school, in Muzaffarpur district in north Bihar, the plaster sometimes falls in the corridor outside the two classrooms. “We dread walking on this veranda,” says one teacher.

All the 119 students crowd into the pink building, which was painted six months ago but is already peeling. They share space with two goats, which play on the corridor, and occasionally wander in to be petted. Under the crumbling roof of the corridor stand two motorcycles – they belong to the teachers.

“The school was established in 1982, but there is no boundary wall, no wash room, no sports ground, and no space to store the midday meal supplies,” says the headmaster, Sanju Kumar. He travels 15 kilometres daily, one way, to reach the village. The six teachers of the school use the neighbours’ bathrooms, they say, but the children must simply go in the open, or not at all. The school has no space to build, say the teachers.

At the middle school, a kilometre away, at Budhnagra Jagannath Malikana Tola, established in 2002, there are 10 teachers and 283 students. The principal, Umesh Ram, is sad that the school has only two rooms. Students of Class 8 sit on the veranda, and those of Classes 1 and 2 under a tree behind the kitchen.

The teachers complain about space constraints and the fact that the area floods in the rains. The students say their midday meal is tasteless. “Sometimes there are insects in it. We want our food to be better,” says one student.

The district education officer says he has written to his superiors in Bihar’s Education Department about the schools’ demands.

In the adjoining Vaishali district, the primary school at Mirpur Pathad Rajdeo Rai Ka Tola does not even have a building of its own. It runs in a community centre, established in 2014.

The school, from Classes 1 to 5, runs in a single

The school has no playground, no wash room, no kitchen shed, nothing at all

UDAY KUMAR
Teacher, Bihar

room, which is also stuffed with rows of department almirahs and midday meal utensils, tables, and broken chairs. The students sit on new benches. There are 91 students and three teachers, including the headmaster, Vinod Kumar.

“The school has no playground, no wash room, no kitchen shed, nothing at all,” says Uday Kumar, a teacher who travels about 40 km every day to reach the school by motorcycle.

“You can imagine the difficulties we face here every day. When more students come to school than the space allows, they have to sit under a huge banyan tree nearby to study,” says Kumar.

The Block Education Department of Rajaparkar could not be reached. On its department website, the Bihar government reads, “Education is the pillar upon which the fate of a country depends.”

Rajasthan
In Unchki village in Rajasthan’s Deeg district, there is no public road to the Rajkiya Prathamik Vidyalaya, which is blocked by a graveyard on one side and high boundary walls on the other. Locals say students have no option but to walk through the graveyard. From there, they traverse a thin, muddy path, surrounded by overgrown plants and shrubs, to go to school. A student of Class 3 says, “*Bach bach ke aana padhta hai. Keechar bohut hai* (We have to come cautiously; it is very muddy).”

Students say corridors are their classrooms. One student says, “The teacher teaches both Class 4 and 5 together.” This is either because there are not enough rooms in the building to accommodate all of them or no electricity. The district falls under the National Capital Region and is only 165 km from Delhi.

“My children come home during the middle of the day and then go back to school,” explains Sakira Khan, a mother of two children who study in this school. This is because there are no wash rooms. Behind the school there are two brick structures with overgrown shrubs. They open onto the fields and have no doors. In Rajkiya Prathamik Vidyalaya in Amrooka village in the same district, again students say they sit on a corridor outside the classroom which does not have electricity. There are 85 students enrolled in the school. The Rajkiya Prathamik Vidyalaya, in Bas Bolkheda village in Deeg, is located on a hill and caters to students from the neighbourhood. As they leave, students say they have had fun, running around the classroom. They say there are two teachers; neither had come that day. A temporary teacher assigned from another school visits them after finishing his day at the school where he is posted.

The teachers in all the three schools say they have received orders from their supervisors not to speak to the media. One says, on the condition of anonymity, “We keep writing to the district authorities about the shortage of classrooms, but they say they do not have the budget.”

There is one empty teaching post in one of the schools. “We are forced to manage,” explains another teacher. “We all take turns to teach students from another class.”

The teachers also admit that many students

do not attend class because of infrastructural issues. While there is no permanent principal, a nodal officer in each block frequently visits the school, serving as the principal. In all three schools, the teachers say 50-60% of the total enrolled students come to school daily.

Locals sitting under a tree near the school say children do not learn much in government schools compared to private schools. Aas Mohammad, whose granddaughter skipped school for the day, says, “It is not possible to send all my grandchildren to private schools. They may have all the facilities, but they cost some ₹18,000 a year.”

Locals also allege that governments do not pay attention to their requests because they live in predominantly Muslim areas.

District Magistrate Mayank Manish says if Education Department officials receive complaints from schools, they act on them quickly. “The government is focused on education. It is trying to increase or convert funds wherever possible. Teachers’ vacancies are filled regularly, and online materials are made available in case of a shortage of teachers,” he says. On specific concerns such as the lack of toilets and pathways to schools, he says officials will look into the matter.

Uttar Pradesh
Aworried Digvijay Narayan (name changed), 44, asks his wife which non-essential expenses they can cut to reduce their monthly spending.

Narayan, who lives in an urban settlement near Dayal Chauraha in Gomti Nagar, Lucknow, is a cab driver. He is considering moving his daughter, Payal Gautam (name changed), 11, from the Government Primary School Gwari in Vikas Khand in Lucknow to a private school after she suffered a prolonged illness due to a urinary tract infection. “We believe the dirty wash room at the government school caused the infection. She had symptoms for more than 10 days,” he says.

He is anxious about arranging an additional ₹1,000 per month for the move. “My son goes to a private school; now both will go together. I will ask the management to give me some concession,” he says.

Payal says she travels over a kilometre by foot to go to school every day. Drinking water, she says, comes “in fits and starts.” About the wash room, she says she will never use it again. “The water facilities in the wash room are dysfunctional at times, so we have to arrange for water from the houses nearby.”

Narayan feels the dismal infrastructure also impacts productivity. “A peaceful atmosphere, like what you find in a private school, will help the student focus on their studies,” he says.

Madhya Pradesh
Around 1 p.m., five teachers sit in two classrooms at the government middle school in Hirapur village of Madhya Pradesh’s Sehore district, about 40 km from the State capital, Bhopal. Students are absent; they have not returned to classes after the festival of Raksha Bandhan.

The school is located in a dilapidated building. It is in the same premises as the village panchayat office and a community centre ground. The four-room school, which includes a small principal’s office, has only 22 students enrolled across eight classes. While teachers have chairs and tables, there are no benches for students. The classrooms have mats on the floor, dim lighting, and broken almirahs. While one classroom does not have fans, the other two have fans that are out of order. The walls and the roofs have rainwater seeping through during the monsoon.

Next to the school building is a small pit filled with dirty water covered by green moss and surrounded by bushes. The community centre ground is filled with cattle dung. Stray dogs roam

around. There are two wash room complexes on the opposite sides of the ground – one for the staff and the other for students. However, in the students’ complex, only one of the two wash rooms is functional, forcing female and male students to use the same toilet.

The school in-charge, Mahendra Singh Sisodia, says students from eight classes are being accommodated in three classrooms after the primary school building on the same premises was abandoned about six months ago because of its poor condition.

Most of the 22 students at the school are from marginalised communities, he says. “Other dominant communities in the village send their children to private schools, so this school does not get much attention,” he says. Since the premises do not have a gate, some people also use the ground for drinking at night, he adds.

A small room is used as the kitchen to prepare the midday meal for the children. Sisodia says that the self-help group designated to prepare the meal stopped its services about three months ago. “I have informed Education Department officials at the district level and they have instructed me to make arrangements for now. So, I have been buying ration for the school. Hopefully the money will be reimbursed soon,” he says, adding that the school also does not have drinking water supply and the students bring bottles from home.

The school falls under the Ichhawar Assembly segment, the constituency of the State Revenue Minister, Karan Singh Verma.

About 20 km from Hirapur is Sarvar village in Bhopal’s rural outskirts. The government middle school here appears clean and well maintained. There is a boundary wall and a gate, and the campus has plants. However, a conversation with the students reveals a different story. The classrooms don’t have an electricity connection and many do not have fans or lights. The switchboards have been removed and the wires taped shut.

A Class 8 student says, “Since there is no light in the classrooms, it is difficult to study here, especially during the monsoon when we have to shut the windows. The summer heat is intolerable. While I like my school and teachers, this is one thing that we all want fixed at the earliest.”

The school has a strength of 104 students. All the three teachers for Classes 6-8 are on leave, while the principal, Suresh Malviya, is at an official training exercise. There are only two teachers of the primary classes present.

Over the phone, Malviya says that the school building has been in poor condition for about five years. The electricity connection had to be cut since water was leaking through the ceiling and there was risk of it reaching the wires, he says.

“We have been sending annual proposals for repairs for five years but no one has taken cognisance of it. The school gets ₹25,000 annually for miscellaneous works. It’s not enough to repair the building. The money is utilised for hiring a worker once a month to clean the wash rooms,” Malviya says.

Another teacher says, “The floor, the boundary wall, and the gate – or anything that appears in a good condition – was built by the village panchayat after a school alumnus became its head a few years ago. There is barely any attention on such matters from the department.”

Students complain of poor quality of food and say that many prefer to bring food from home. “The dal is watery and the rotis are often burnt or not properly cooked,” says a Class 7 student.

At both schools, the worried staff asked if this was an inspection by the CJP or whether permission had been obtained from senior officials.

An official at the School Education Department highlights a gap in the government’s approach towards different kinds of schools in the State. “Over the past few years, the focus has been on flagship institutions like Sandipani (earlier known as CM Rise) Schools and Excellence schools, so small rural schools, which were already not in a very good condition, have been struggling even for basic infrastructure.”

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275 Indians still missing, 169 rescued, says Ministry

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

The Kailash Manasarovar Yatra of 2026 has ended officially as all Indian pilgrims have left Chinese territory bordering Nepal, following the flash flood in the Bhote Koshi river on August 26, the External Affairs Ministry said on Friday.

Apart from the Government of India-assisted tour of Mount Kailash, travellers, who chose private travel agencies used the Nepali route through Gyirong border crossing of China. On August 26, significant number of pilgrims and travellers went missing from the Gyirong border port which was hit by the flash flood.

Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal confirmed that 275 Indian nationals remain missing till now and 169 Indians have been rescued. He indicated the numbers of the missing may fluctuate as some survivors are still being discovered.

Official sources said that with the evacuation of the private travellers, all Indians have left the Tibetan region bordering Nepal which hosts travellers during the season when China allow the yatra.

On Nepal Minister seeking damages, India says climate change a common challenge

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Climate change is a “common challenge” and developed nations that are “historically” the highest emitters must lead the process of finding a solution to this crisis, Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson of the External Affairs Ministry, said on Friday.

The remarks came in response to Nepal Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal, who said that as the three biggest emitters of greenhouse gases, the U.S., China, and India should bear responsibility for climate change, and sought compensation from the three nations following the flash flood in Nepal last month.

“India has consistently maintained that climate change is a common challenge and action in this regard must be based on the principle of common but differentiated responsibilities and respective capabilities. Developed countries who historically are responsible for the emissions and have contributed overwhelmingly to this present crisis must take the lead in reducing emissions and supporting developing



Aid in time: Humanitarian assistance sent by India being received by Nepalese Minister Mahabir Pun in Kathmandu. @MEAINDIA/X

countries by way of finance and technology transfer to meet this challenge,” said Mr. Jaiswal.

India has sent consignments of relief assistance, including a large team of tunnel rescue specialists, to Nepal since the disaster struck on August 26. Mr. Jaiswal described India as a “friend and partner” that will continue to extend help as Nepal deals with the aftermath of this crisis. He also noted that Nepal Prime Minister Balendra Shah has thanked India in the Nepal Parliament for the assistance.

On September 2, Mr. Khanal referred to Nepal’s diplomatic approach

ahead of the UN General Assembly’s annual session, which will begin in New York later this month, and said his country sees the crisis through the prism of “justice and compensation” and not “aid”.

“The major industrial emitters - such as China, which is the world’s top emitter, the United States at number two, and India at number three - have a historical responsibility to compensate vulnerable nations like Nepal,” he said.

He subsequently denied seeking compensation and expressed “deep gratitude” for the help that India has been providing to Nepal.

Belgian port can be key to Indian exports: De Wever

Belgian Prime Minister pitches Port of Antwerp-Bruges as India’s gateway to Europe; Commerce Minister Goyal says two countries could deepen collaboration in the lab-grown diamond sector

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever on Friday pitched the Port of Antwerp-Bruges as a gateway for Indian exports to Europe. He is in Mumbai for a high-level dialogue on the India-EU Free Trade Agreement.

“The FTA would strengthen trade, create opportunities for businesses, young talent and investment, and make the Indian and European economies more resilient to global disruptions. The Port of Antwerp-Bruges will be a key logistics link between India and Europe creating opportunities in diamonds, pharmaceuticals, food processing, maritime services, green hydrogen and infrastructure,” Mr. De Wever said.

“The agreement is expected to eliminate or reduce tariffs on more than 95% of Indian and European goods exports,” he added.

Bilateral trade between both countries stood at approximately \$13.08 billion in 2025-26.



All ears: Belgian Prime Minister Bart De Wever in conversation with Union Minister Piyush Goyal, in Mumbai, on Friday. PTI

“More and more voices today are calling for barriers to go up, for markets to be shut off, and for tariffs to be imposed. Some do this entirely arbitrarily. In doing so, they inflict serious economic damage on their trading partners, making them dependent and turning them into vassals,” said Mr. De Wever.

‘Invest in India’

Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal invited Belgian companies to invest in India, saying Belgium’s technology, innovation and capital could be combined with India’s scale, talent and

around 25 years, would create opportunities for farmers, fishermen, MSMEs, startups, women entrepreneurs, manufacturers and service providers across India and Europe.

“The India-EU FTA brings together around two billion people, representing about a quarter of global GDP, a third of world trade and a market of around \$24 trillion,” Mr. Goyal said.

He said all 27 EU countries were supportive of completing the remaining formalities.

On India-Belgium cooperation in the diamond sector, Mr. Goyal said the two countries could deepen collaboration in design and co-creation in gems and jewellery, including lab-grown diamonds, while also working towards greater cooperation in technology and certification centred around Antwerp, Mumbai and Surat.

India-Belgium gems and jewellery trade stood at around \$3.5 billion in 2025-26, according to Gem & Jewellery Export Promotion Council.



Valiant arms: Army personnel lift a worker who was trapped inside a tunnel at a hydropower project in Nepal’s Rasuwa district. AFP

Indian volunteers take relief to remote Nepal communities

Lavpreet Kaur
NEW DELHI

For nearly 20 members of a family in Trishuli, one room has become home after devastating floods destroyed homes, cut roads and left several families without basic amenities. A week on, Indian volunteers are travelling up to 10 hours through damaged mountain roads and bridges to take food, bedding and household essentials to such communities, while some areas of Rasuwa remain accessible only by helicopter.

“Almost a week after the floods, some of the more accessible areas are slowly seeing relief reach them, but our biggest concern now is reaching the families who have been most severely affected and remain isolated,” Manohar Naidu, a Khalsa Aid volunteer, told *The Hindu* from Nepal.

In Trishuli, Tupche and other remote communities, volunteers have found several families living together with little shelter or basic household equipment.

The volunteers also described mass burials being carried out as mortuaries run out of space, with forest land being cleared to accommodate bodies as the death toll rises and many remain unidentified.

“Our immediate support is focused on essential relief such as food, clothing, bedding and basic household requirements. At the same time, we are

assessing and documenting what each community will need for longer-term recovery,” Mr. Naidu said.

Tough terrain

Reaching the affected communities has become a major logistical challenge.

Some journeys from Kathmandu to areas such as Trishuli take nine to 10 hours, with damaged or completely washed-out roads and bridges forcing volunteers to take longer routes. Teams are travelling in trucks carrying supplies, while demand for 4x4 vehicles has surged, making them difficult to arrange and prompting suppliers to raise prices.

The problem is more acute in Rasuwa, where some affected areas have no road connectivity and helicopters are the only practical option. Each trip can cost around \$2,000, significantly increasing the cost of delivering relief.

“So the challenge is not simply having relief material available. The biggest challenge is getting that aid to the families who need it most,” Mr. Naidu said.

The organisation is procuring supplies locally, but demand is outstripping availability for mattresses, solar lights and other household items.

“People need much more than food. They are asking how they are going to rebuild their lives,” Mr. Naidu said.

Ten Indian volunteers are currently involved in logistics, assessments, packing and distribution.

Rahul likely to address students in 28 cities under Congress campaign

Sandeep Phukan
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, Rahul Gandhi, is likely to address as many as 28 student interaction programmes under the Congress’s *Chhatron Ki Goonj* campaign as the party seeks to build a sustained outreach among Gen Z youth, students, and young voters ahead of the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

The programme, which began as an initiative to engage directly with students and young people, is now being positioned by the Congress as one of its major organisational and political outreach exercises.

At its meeting on August 19, the Congress Working Committee approved a plan to expand *Chhatron Ki Goonj* to as many as 800 cities over the next few months, reflecting the party’s attempt to turn what began as a series of student



Nation’s future: Students at the *Chhatron Ki Goonj* programme in Prayagraj on August 8. @INCINDIA/X

interactions into a nationwide youth outreach programme.

Sources told *The Hindu* that Congress general secretary (organisation) K.C. Venugopal has instructed party leader Kanhaiya Kumar, who oversees the functioning of the party’s frontal organisations, to immediately scale up the campaign to 100 cities by appointing coordinators.

While senior Congress leaders will address some

of the proposed interactions, Mr. Gandhi is expected to cover 28 cities identified for the first phase of the expansion. So far, Mr. Gandhi has addressed student programmes in Kota, Prayagraj, Dehradun, and Pune. Another interaction is scheduled in Indore in the coming days.

As per sources, Mr. Gandhi is expected to address at least one major city in every State. “In the Northeast, he will proba-

bly go to Guwahati; in Bihar, Patna and Purnea; and in Jharkhand, he will address students in Ranchi,” said the party insider familiar with the programme.

To win young voters

The campaign assumes significance as the Congress and the BJP intensify their efforts to retain or win over young voters.

Since 2013, the BJP has built a formidable youth outreach architecture through its organisational network and extensive digital presence, while the Congress has been a latecomer. Now, with growing concerns over issues such as unemployment, education, competitive examinations etc., the Congress is seeking to pitch Mr. Gandhi as someone representing young voices. The challenge is to convert the student interactions into an enduring political network and, eventually, electoral support for 2029.

Congress plans organisational revamp in U.P. ahead of polls

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress is set to revamp its organisational structure in Uttar Pradesh ahead of next year’s Assembly election, with the party finalising a new set of District Congress Committee (DCC) presidents as part of its ongoing organisational exercise.

On Friday, Congress general secretary K.C. Venugopal said detailed discussions had been held over two days with the party’s Uttar Pradesh in-charge Rajendra Pal Gautam, Pradesh Congress Committee president Ajay Rai, Congress Legislature Party leader Aradhana Mishra, and other senior functionaries to finalise the new DCC presidents. The deliberations fo-



Party leaders discuss plans to strengthen grassroots network, finalise district-level presidents.

cused on the strategy for the ongoing *Sangathan Srijan Abhiyan* in the State and preparations for the Assembly election.

“In the run-up to the upcoming Assembly election, we are gearing up to revamp our organisation to further consolidate the Opposition’s position in U.P.,” Mr. Venugopal said in a

post on X. He said the 2024 Lok Sabha election results showed that the people of Uttar Pradesh had decided to “throw out the BJP” and asserted that the Congress would play a “critical role” in ensuring its defeat.

The organisational exercise comes as the Congress seeks to strengthen its grassroots network and consolidate its position in the State ahead of the next electoral contest.

Mr. Venugopal is said to have separately discussed the party’s Uttar Pradesh plans with Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi and party general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadra.

Party sources said the process of making new appointments at all levels in Uttar Pradesh will begin this month.

CPI(ML) to seek reforms in education in Bihar, U.P.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The CPI (ML) Liberation is set to launch a one-month campaign seeking reforms in the education sector which will begin in Patna with a public meeting on September 6.

It will highlight issues ranging from inadequate school and college infrastructure to concerns over the implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP).

Primarily focused on Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, party campaigners will travel extensively across the region to establish contact with young voters ahead of the Assembly elections in the State scheduled for early next year.

Congress stands with ‘all daughters’ fighting for justice, says leader

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress stands with “all the daughters” fighting for justice and will extend every possible support to them, All India Mahila Congress president Alka Lamba said on Friday, while raising the alleged assault of student activist Nishu Azad’s father and other cases involving young women.

She also alleged that self-styled “Hindutva influencer” Swatantra Bhardwaj had in a video recounted incidents of violence and used derogatory language against Dalits.

Addressing a press conference, Ms. Lamba said the party and Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi stood with Ms. Azad, journalists Shaheen Khan and Nafisa Khan, and student activist Akriti Chaudhary, who participated in a protest at Jan- tar Mantar.

Referring to the alleged assault of Ms. Azad’s father during the protest, Ms. Lamba said the student had only exercised her democratic right to express her views. She demanded action under appropriate provisions of law, including those relating to attempted murder against



Alka Lamba

Bhardwaj, who is an accused in the matter.

Referring to the incident where the two journalists had accused the Delhi Police of detaining and beating them with sticks while covering an event attended by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and Union Home Minister Amit Shah, the Mahila Congress chief demanded the immediate suspension of the police personnel involved and sought the release of CCTV footage of the incident.

Ms. Lamba spoke about Ms. Chaudhary who was arrested under the National Security Act (NSA) in Noida, which was later revoked by the Allahabad High Court.

“The Congress stands with these daughters, including Nishu Azad, and will extend all possible support to ensure that they get justice,” she said.

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DIPR/2760/Tender/2026 TNPL - Maker of bagasse based eco-friendly Paper		

One terrorist was killed on Friday during a joint operation by the Army and Jammu and Kashmir Police deep inside a forest area in Budgam district, officials said. The operation was launched based on information about the movement of a suspected group of terrorists from Pulwama district towards Budgam, the officials said. “Based on specific intelligence input, a joint search operation was launched by the Indian Army, J&K Police and CRPF in Ashdar Gali, Budgam,” the Srinagar-based Chinar Corps posted on X. The operation is under way as the forces are still looking for another terrorist, who is believed to be holed up in the same area. PTI

A fire broke out at Asian Hospital in Chhatrapati Sambhaji Nagar in Maharashtra, following which 58 patients, including nine newborns, were rescued. According to the hospital authorities, the newborns were shifted to the nearby Ghati Hospital, MGM Hospital, and Sanjeevani Hospital. The incident occurred around 2.15 a.m. due to a short circuit in an AC unit in the NICU. "The duty staff noticed smoke coming out of AC and immediately activated the code red, using their presence of mind, and evacuated the newborns," said Shoab Hashmi, managing director, Asian Hospital, adding that they managed to avoid a big tragedy because the hospital fire system is intact.

Press Trust of India
GAYAJI (BIHAR)

Jan Suraaj Party founder Prashant Kishor on Friday urged the Narendra Modi government at the Centre to bring out a 'White Paper' on alleged financial irregularities in Ayodhya's Ram Temple and "fix accountability".

Speaking to reporters in Gayatri, Mr. Kishor also waded into the controversy over GDP figures, alleging that hardships suffered by the people belied the claims of a high growth rate by the government.

"What will merely appointing a CEO achieve if the people who were previously involved in managing the affairs are let off the hook? The government must bring out a White Paper on the financial irregularities that have taken place," Mr. Kishor said.

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has sought the help of the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) to map IT infrastructure and vacant spaces in government institutions to establish standard testing centres (STCs). These centres will facilitate computer-based testing (CBT) for NTA examinations, including the high-stakes National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET).

The NTA plans to shift NEET to CBT mode next year. Nearly 22 lakh students appeared for the NEET-UG, 2026, which was held in a pen-and-paper format. The examination became embroiled in a paper leak controversy and had to be re-conducted, leading to widespread protests and the resignation of Dharmendra Prad-

Top court says it is 'crying need of the hour' to stop attrition of experienced judicial talent otherwise access to justice would remain a mere chimera; only 7 States have responded positively to SC's call, while others are hesitant or plain fence-sitting

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

As 5.18 crore cases lie pending in district courts across the country, the Supreme Court has sent a distress call to States to enhance the retirement age of experienced judicial officers from 60 to 62 years.

The court said the “crying need of the hour” is to stop the attrition of the experienced judicial talent lest access to justice remain a mere chimera due to unfilled posts.

Only seven States have so far responded positively to the SOS from the Supreme Court. Chhattisgarh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Sikkim, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal have agreed to enhance the retirement age of their judicial officers.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, in a September 1 order published on Friday, directed these State governments to amend the service rules within two months. The State High Court concerned would enhance the age of superannuation to 62 years of judicial officers,

 Most of the recruitment drives undertaken in the various States have not resulted in optimum recruitment or in the filling up of the sanctioned cadre strength, and a yawning gap between the sanctioned and working strength persists across the board

SUPREME COURT



subject to their suitability assessment, on their attainment of 60 years of age.

The other States and Union Territories have varied between a direct negative response to plain fence-sitting.

The court has directed them to take a decision on enhancement of retirement age of their judicial officers to 62 years in two weeks. These States include Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Kerala, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Odisha, Punjab, Rajasthan, Telangana, Tripura, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, NCT of Delhi, Jammu and Kash-

Their hesitation, the court discovered, was fuelled by a sense of insecurity over the financial burden the move would entail. Plus, these States apprehend that employees in other State services would also demand parity.

The Bench said the apprehensions of these States were entirely misconceived. Judicial officers do a specialised service.

Benefit to society
“The alleged financial burden that would be thrown on the State exchequer on account of the enhancement of the superannuation age as a result of the payment of the maximum salary in the pay scale to the officers for a further

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

An asteroid hunter. A Maths wizard. A trailblazer in a coal mining community. A Special Olympics hockey coach. These are among the 82 educators from across the country who will receive the National Teachers' Awards on Saturday. President Droupadi Murmu will confer the awards.

Among the awardees are 48 school teachers, 21 faculty members in higher education, and 13 trainers from the Union Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship. Among the faculty in higher education are proponents of Indian Knowledge Systems, including Vaastu Shastra, Bhagavad Gita, and others.

One of the awardees, Haryana-based Anil Kaushik, known as the 'Math Wi-

Among the awardees are 48 school teachers, 21 faculty members in higher education, and 13 trainers from MSDE

zard', built a state-of-the-art physical Maths lab containing over 40 original learning models, alongside a 12-section virtual mathematics lab with 30 'Harbans puzzles'.

He has co-authored textbooks on Vedic Mathematics and published 22 teaching modules on the national DIKSHA portal.

Divyendu Sen from Rajasthan, another recipient of the award, is a teacher in a government school who bridged rural classrooms with deep-space science by training local students to track and hunt asteroids. He has pioneered low-cost solutions, including an AI-

enabled Biology education model, a Virtual Biology Laboratory, and 'Tree Talk', a QR-based botanical learning system.

Rajasthan-based teacher Vartika Gulati is an awardee who teaches at the Government Girls Upper Primary School in Jaipur. She turns abstract concepts into everyday experiences – teaching Algebra with groundnuts and geometry with kites. Her initiative, *Prashno Se Vigyan* (Science through questions), replaces rote learning with student-led inquiry.

Odisha-based teacher Padaraj Nayak, based at the Government High School, Alipaling, is receiving the award for guiding students to build over 50 prototypes, including a low-cost automatic plate-washing machine that earned a Government of India patent.



The NTA plans to shift NEET to CBT mode next year. The NEET-UG 2026 was held in a pen-and-paper format. ANI

han as Union Education Minister.

Infrastructure audit
Following the NTA's request, the AICTE wrote to Vice-Chancellors of government-run technical universities and heads of AICTE-approved government institutes on August 31 to assess their infrastructure.

The AICTE has directed all approved government

engineering colleges, polytechnics, university departments, and technical institutes to submit comprehensive data regarding their facilities by September 15.

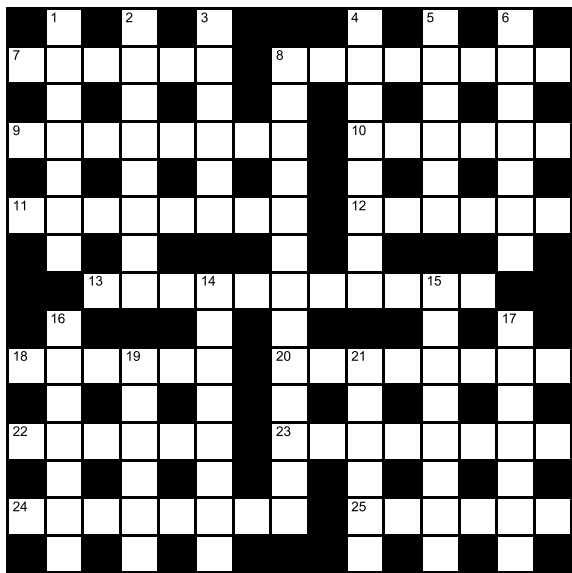
The move follows an NTA directive issued on August 5 to address the progressive migration of national-level examinations to online and CBT modes. "By establishing

STCs in government institutions, the NTA seeks to create a wider, highly secure, and geographically distributed network of testing hubs," the NTA officials said.

tion is strictly restricted to government-owned and approved institutes.

To ensure seamless exam delivery without technical glitches, the NTA and AICTE are assessing local and external networks for Internet connectivity.

Power failures during high-stakes exams lead to the risk of re-conducting exams. Hence, AICTE has stated that institutes must detail their electrical backup capabilities. Furthermore, details on surveillance systems are sought, requiring information on existing CCTV coverage across all labs and connecting corridors.



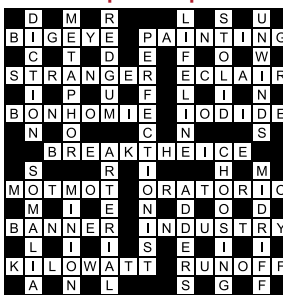
Across

- 7 Extremely corrupt amateur (egghead) agent missing now
and then (6)
- 8 Forego pals? Not so casually in child's play (8)
- 9 Topped stretching in workout (8)
- 10 Exiled man in Germany refused entry to begin with (6)
- 11 Doubt dead legends? (4,4)

- 12 Dismiss wriggling of a fly (3-3)
- 13 Ya! Count over and over in book-keeping? (11)
- 18 A Republican member of parliament has appeal in sweater? (6)
- 20 Gasp! I ran towards hiding suitor (8)
- 22 Elitist returns first class miniature plant (6)
- 23 Formless, trendy confectionery? No, pass! (8)
- 24 Rich Neapolitan Sauce from one of New York's Five Families (8)
- 25 A grave tribute? (6)
- Down**
- 1 Runner's back around end of June with Professor's reward (7)
- 2 Once in a while, every idiotic criminal losing it perhaps (8)
- 3 Live? So soon! Will I win debate finally (6)
- 4 Animal upset about bloomer (8)
- 5 Some enjoy GIF featuring revolutionary figure (6)
- 6 Bluff about extremely feisty char (7)
- 8 Kindling Spooner's conflict with a story-teller? (8,1,4)
- 14 Devil came through? (8)
- 15 Doh! These ride sharing arrangements made a mess of a school drop? (3,5)
- 16 Impudent when cycling around upright, humble cavalryman (7)
- 17 To some extent buffoons tag equilibrists in view of the audience (7)
- 19 Handgun's part of a blossom, we hear (6)
- 21 Spot alien's bag (6)

			9		6		4	
	9	3		4			6	5
			8					
8	2				9	4		
		1				9		
		4	2				8	1
					3			
7	5			9		1	3	
	8		1		5			

Solution to previous puzzle



Solution to yesterday's Sudoku



Gugga Navami

Janmashtami falls on the Ashtami thithi of Krishna Paksha in the month of Bhadrapada during the Rohini nakshatra. Sri Krishna is regarded as the eighth avatar of Vishnu. It commemorates the birth of Bala Gopal, which is believed to have taken place with miraculous celestial intervention, said Prof. Kumool Abbi.

Kamsa, the king of Mathura was the brother of Devaki. It had been prophesised that the eighth child of Devaki would lead to the death of the evil Kamsa. Therefore, Devaki and her husband Vasudev were imprisoned and all children born to them were killed. Spiritual literature states that divine intervention put Mathura to sleep and Vasudev saved baby Krishna after birth from Kamsa's clutches and handed him over to the care of Yashoda and Nanda, eventually paving the way for the destruction of Kamsa.

Usually, the day after Janmashtami is observed as Gugga Naumi (Navami), a popular folk religious festival celebrated across Rajasthan, Haryana, Punjab, Jammu and Kashmir, Uttar Pradesh and other parts of North India. Gugga Naumi reflects the syncretic and fluid traditions of India, where He is worshipped by people of different religions and sects.

The celebration of Gugga Naumi begins on the day of the Rakhi and continues for nine days, beginning with pilgrimage to Gugga Medi village in Hanumanagarh district of Rajasthan. Devotional songs called 'pir ke solle' are sung by the *gugga mandlis*, prayers and fairs take place at Gugga's shrines, called *marhis*, dotted across villages in north India, reflecting Gugga's affinity with the subalterns.

Weekend Sport



Mature Gurindervir battles stopwatch, questions, injuries

India's fastest man has endured a challenging few months since breaching the 10.1-second barrier. Ahead of the Asian Games, he is determined to take control of his life and his running

Uthra Ganesan

Two years ago, Gurindervir Singh stamped his return to the top rung of sprinters in India by winning the National Inter-State Athletics Championships in the fading light at Panchkula. It was only 10.32 seconds, but it brought him the spotlight and support needed to kick his almost stagnant career back into gear. In time, it led to him becoming the fastest Indian on the track, raising expectations of a historic sub-10 run in the most glamorous event in athletics.

Familiar situation

As the 25-year-old prepares for the upcoming Asian Games, the parallels between 2024 and now are hard to miss, even for the man himself. Back then, Gurindervir was the meet record holder at the Nationals, but, in the three years since he had clocked 10.27s (Patiala, 2021), others had raced far ahead. Coupled with injuries, lack of sufficient nutrition and uncertainty over his sporting future, he had been forced to play catch-up. Now, with the all-important continental meet looming large, Gurindervir is again battling the stopwatch on the track and questions and injuries off it. The only Indian to go under 10.1s has had a torrid few months ever since the incredible two days in May when the national record switched hands thrice, Gurindervir eventually making it his own in 10.09s. He injured his hamstring, crashed out in the first round at the Commonwealth Games and finished a lowly seventh at the World Athletics Con-

That Gurindervir took pressure. This one has evolved, he has learnt from all this



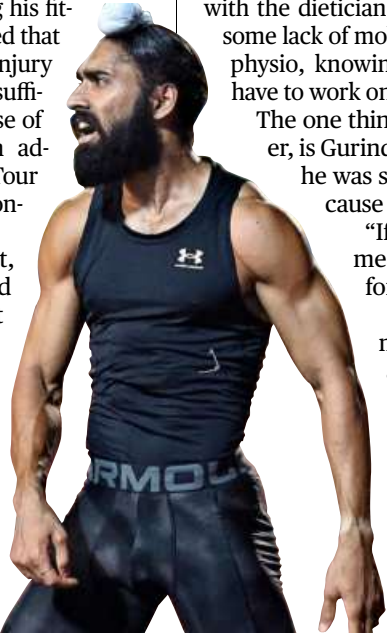
GURINDERVIR

tinental Tour in Bhubaneswar. The big difference now, however, is the support he has access to. Picked up by the Reliance Foundation after the 2024 outing and working under the watchful eyes of its athletics director James Hillier at the high performance centre in Navi Mumbai, Gurindervir is already back to peak training ahead of his biggest outing of the year. "He's had a good couple of weeks of training. He's getting back into good shape but he's looking to get into peak 100m shape within the next two weeks. That's what I'm hoping for," Hillier said before getting into the details of Gurindervir's technical strengths and weaknesses. "CWG... there were certain elements of his race that were quite good from a coaching perspective. I'm very happy with the first 60-70 meters of his race. What we've been working on in the last few weeks is getting him to extrapolate that speed over the full 100m. "We've been working pretty hard to get that last bit of the race sorted. I've put some specific training in place for that. We have a competition in Delhi on September 10 and that's going to be a key competition. We'll get to see exactly where he is, where the training is going and how well he finishes the race there, that'll give us very good information," Hillier explained. The transformation The man himself has gone from being an emotional and often-stressed youngster to a more confident and mature professional who is determined to take control of his life and his running, something Hillier also acknowledged. The transformation began in March last year, when he

broke the national record for the first time with a 10.20s run at the Indian Grand Prix 1. Gurindervir had been battling stomach ulcers that weakened his body and naysayers who tried to break his spirit. Both were spillovers from his time in obscurity before 2024 – when a poor diet and dirty water stripped away his gut lining. He could barely keep anything in and lost almost 15kgs in a fortnight even as people, known and unknown, sniggered that he was finished. "If you had asked last year's Gurindervir about handling the pressure, maybe he would have been in stress. That time too, all this happened with me – interviews, phone calls, questions, expectations. I was not sleeping at night," he said. "Back then, I couldn't get out of it. I was thinking about what to say in the next interview when I should have been thinking about how to improve. When I ran in the Fed Cup [in 2025], I cramped and it stressed me even more because I had claimed I would do a lot in the interviews. That Gurindervir took pressure. This one has evolved, he has learnt from all this." A large part of the credit for that, he insisted, went to Hillier for keeping him away from a lot of negativity. "If it wasn't for him, I would have been in a very bad, stressful situation. The coach motivated me a lot. He gave me the right guidance on how to deal with it." A lot of people had been critical of his inclusion for Glasgow, questioning his fitness, but Hillier has already clarified that the problem was not carrying an injury into competition but the lack of sufficient races before the CWG because of the injury. That issue has been addressed although the Continental Tour event highlighted the issues that continue to plague his race plan. "At the Bhubaneswar event, you'll see he was in a really good position at 60-70m and then sort of fell away, which I expected to happen based on what's been happening in training. It's just how he's put together," Hillier said. "Many 100m athletes run the race in different ways. Guri is a very good accelerator and that's just his natural strength. He won



I'm very happy with the first 60-70 meters of his race. What we've been working on in the last few weeks is getting him to extrapolate that speed over the full 100m JAMES HILLIER Athletics director, Reliance Foundation the national indoor 60m earlier in the year, broke the national record in that with a very fast time of 6.60s. Someone like an Animesh [Kujur] or an Amlan [Borgohain], these guys tend to finish strong, that's their natural strength. We must train them to their strengths and then work alongside that to manage their weaknesses." Listening to his body Gurindervir has also learnt to listen to his body. "I have worked on everything. What I eat and how much, how much I travel. If I am feeling any pain, how much effort do I have to put into the workout? If I am doing an endurance workout, how do I do it? "In weight training, I have set levels I must achieve every month. It's the same on track as well. I will train as much as my body needs. I discuss with the dietician how much food I need. I had some lack of mobility before, so sitting with the physio, knowing which muscles and joints I have to work on so that I can run better." The one thing that hasn't changed, however, is Gurindervir's conviction. The reason he was stressed, he explained, was because what he says matters to him. "If I say something, it has to have meaning. Words are important for me. "If I claim or promise something and I cannot do it, it affects me. That's my nature. My father had a dream, I started running to fulfil that dream. People said Indians can't be competitive in 100m, I was determined to do it. It will take some time, but it will definitely happen."



STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	12,800	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	7,790	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	7,160	17
4	Felix Auger-Aliassime	26	4,640	22
5	Novak Djokovic	39	3,770	16
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,720	26
7	Alex de Minaur	27	3,650	24
8	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,580	24
9	Ben Shelton	23	3,480	22
10	Taylor Fritz	28	3,475	22
11	Arthur Fils	22	3,140	18
12	Frances Tiafoe	28	2,680	22
13	Rafael Jodar	19	2,671	22
14	Lorenzo Musetti	24	2,605	22
15	Learner Tien	20	2,565	22



Top Indians ▶

 Sumit Nagal Rank 236 ▼ 2 spots	 Dhakshineswar Suresh Rank 368 ▲ 26 spots
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WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Aryna Sabalenka	28	8,575	18
2	Elena Rybakina	27	8,141	21
3	Jessica Pegula	32	7,265	19
4	Coco Gauff	22	6,704	18
5	Mirra Andreeva	19	5,443	20
6	Linda Noskova	21	5,028	20
7	Karolina Muchova	30	4,983	20
8	Iga Swiatek	25	4,809	19
9	Elina Svitolina	31	4,689	17
10	Amanda Anisimova	25	4,533	15
11	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,980	16
12	Belinda Bencic	29	2,995	18
13	Naomi Osaka	28	2,846	18
14	Iva Jovic	18	2,671	23
15	Victoria Mboko	20	2,531	19

Top Indians ▶

 Sahaja Yamalapalli Rank 341 ▲ 1 spot	 Vaishnavi Adkar Rank 392 ▲ 3 spots
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F1 Drivers' standings

#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	242	6
2	G. Russell	Mercedes	183	2
3	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	183	1
4	L. Norris	McLaren	159	2
5	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	155	1
6	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	112	0
7	O. Piastri	McLaren	104	0
8	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	68	0
9	L. Lawson	RB	49	0
10	P. Gasly	Alpine	44	0
11	A. Lindblad	RB	23	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	19	0
13	O. Bearman	Haas	18	0
14	G. Bortoleto	Audi	10	0
15	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	6	0
16	C. Sainz	Williams	6	0
17	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
18	E. Ocon	Haas	3	0
19	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	3	0
20	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
21	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
22	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0



A.K. Antonelli



G. Russell

F1 Constructors' standings

Pos	Team	Points	Wins
1	Mercedes	425	8
2	Ferrari	338	2
3	McLaren	263	2
4	Red Bull	186	0
5	RB	66	0
6	Alpine	63	0
7	Haas	21	0
8	Audi	16	0
9	Williams	11	0
10	Aston Martin	3	0
11	Cadillac	0	0



Badminton Men's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	Jonatan Christie	87,631	17
2	Christo Popov	87,002	20
3	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	86,915	16
4	Chou Tien Chen	86,580	27
5	Anders Antonsen	85,405	17
6	Shi Yu Qi	84,075	12
7	Alex Lanier	78,715	16
8	Kodai Naraoka	76,530	20
9	Victor Lai	76,465	18
10	Li Shi Feng	71,683	16
11	Alwi Farhan	71,619	19
12	Lin Chun-Yi	71,274	19
13	Lakshya Sen	65,573	21
14	Loh Kean Yew	64,100	20
15	Toma Junior Popov	62,697	20

Top Indians ▶

 Lakshya Sen Rank 13	 Ayush Shetty Rank 20
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Badminton Women's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	An Se Young	1,21,287	15
2	Wang Zhi Yi	1,03,989	16
3	Akane Yamaguchi	1,02,576	18
4	Chen Yu Fei	86,651	15
5	Han Yue	77,038	14
6	Ratchanok Intanon	74,606	20
7	Putri Kusuma Wardani	72,023	18
8	Pornpawee Chochuwong	69,027	16
9	Tomoka Miyazaki	68,106	22
10	P.V. Sindhu	65,401	14
11	Nozomi Okuhara	63,610	18
12	Kim Ga Eun	60,931	16
13	Line Christophersen	57,940	22
14	Michelle Li	57,427	21
15	Mia Blichfeldt	55,803	13

Top Indians ▶

 P.V. Sindhu Rank 10	 Unnati Hooda Rank 25
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Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	856	898
2	Steve Smith	840	947
3	Joe Root	820	932
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Kamindu Mendis	706	784

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	801	841
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	767	908
4	Rohit Sharma	758	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Joe Root	674	810
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Charith Asalanka	659	705
10	Harry Tector	653	730

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	910	910
2	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
3	Abhishek Sharma	819	931
4	Dewald Brevis	806	806
5	Phil Salt	799	881
6	Pathum Nissanka	751	796
7	Tilak Varma	750	845
8	Jos Buttler	748	794
9	Harry Brook	734	734
10	Mitchell Marsh	706	706

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	872	872
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
4	Pat Cummins	841	914
5	Ollie Robinson	831	831
6	Marco Jansen	825	825
7	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
8	Scott Boland	804	820
9	Noman Ali	785	853
10	Josh Hazlewood	783	864

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	714	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Jofra Archer	649	682
4	Keshav Maharaj	645	737
5	Mitchell Santner	644	656
6	Maheesh Theekshana	641	680
7	Bernard Scholtz	613	631
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	602	722
10	Adil Rashid	599	671

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	753	828
2	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
3	Adil Rashid	710	747
4	Adam Zampa	700	746
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Wanindu Hasaranga	668	809
7	Mujeeb Ur Rahman	663	757
7	Varun Chakaravarthy	663	818
9	Mohammad Nawaz	658	672
9	Maheesh Theekshana	658	686

POSITIVE MINDSET

We are always one step ahead of Pakistan, says Deepti



X@BCCIWOMEN

There is no advantage as such. The only thing is that whatever we have won against them (Pakistan), whether it is the Asia Cup or any other matches, we are always one step ahead of them. We just want to play good cricket. That's the mindset — India all-rounder Deepti Sharma ahead of the fixture against Pakistan.

IT'S A DATE!

Japan to host Men in Blue for a T20I on September 22



FILE PHOTO

The Indian men's team will take on Japan in their first-ever T20I meeting on September 22, marking the launch of celebrations for the 75th anniversary of India-Japan diplomatic relations. The match will be played at the Sano International Cricket Ground and the teams will compete for the Suzuki Cup.

CHANGE OF PLANS

India's friendly against Panama in Bengaluru advanced by a day



FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

India's international football friendly against Panama in Bengaluru has been advanced by a day from the scheduled September 26 as the Sree Kanteerava Stadium, the venue of the match, will host the Bengaluru Marathon on September 27. The football game will now be held on September 25.

JOY AND DESPAIR

Gasly stripped of Monaco podium finish, Hadjar reinstated



AFP

Alpine's Pierre Gasly has been stripped of his third place at the Monaco GP and Red Bull's Isack Hadjar was reinstated to third position. Gasly had been given a penalty, but did not serve it during the race and finished third on track. He had been demoted to seventh before an appeal overturned the decision.

India has areas to work on as it meets Pakistan

The Harmanpreet-led team, having already qualified for the semifinals, will be keen to sustain the momentum in the game against its traditional rival; Sana's side looks to seal a final-four spot

ASIA CUP

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

India will be eager to step up the intensity as it faces traditional rival Pakistan in its final Group A match of the women's Asia Cup here on Saturday.

Be it men or women, routinely scheduled India-Pakistan fixtures in multi-team tournaments have not lived up to the off-field hype for a while now. Nothing different is expected at the Dubai International Stadium, with India hoping to get the job done with ease.

The Harmanpreet Kaur-led side had qualified for the semifinals after thrashing Hong Kong by 137 runs on Thursday.

Openers Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma are at the top of their game. Smri-



Next target: India will hope to end the group stage with a win over Pakistan. X@BCCIWOMEN

ti broke a battery of records en route a century against Hong Kong, sending a warning to the other teams.

It is to be noted that the pitches have not been the easiest to bat on.

The likes of Pratika Rawal, Richa Ghosh and Harmanpreet will look to

spend more time in the middle, having not been able to convert starts.

Pressure is mounting on new No. 3 Pratika, who is yet to deliver an impactful knock in the competition.

The Indian team has to develop a pool of power-hitters and fast bowlers to challenge for bigger ho-

nours. The addition of Nandani Sharma to the pace attack is a step in the right direction as she is delivering on her promise while opening alongside spearhead Kranti Gaud.

Pakistan needs to make drastic improvement in batting to compete with India. In its game against

Thailand, Pakistan found itself under pressure in the PowerPlay with the loss of three wickets.

However, it later managed to defend a lowly 119.

The team relies heavily on opener Muneeba Ali and all-rounder Fatima Sana, who is the captain of the side. That will need to change if Pakistan is to seal a final-four spot.

The teams (from):
India: Harmanpreet Kaur (Capt.), Smriti Mandhana (Vice-capt.), Shafali Verma, Bharti Fulmali, Deepti Sharma, Richa Ghosh (wk), G. Kamalini (wk), Arundhati Reddy, Prema Rawat, Radha Yadav, Shree Charani, Renuka Singh, Nandani Sharma, Kranti Gaud, Pratika Rawal.
Pakistan: Fatima Sana (Capt.), Ayesha Zafar, Eman Naseer, Eymen Fatima, Gull Feroza, Momina Riasat, Muneeba Ali Siddiqui (wk), Sadaf Shamas, Nashra Sundhu, Sadia Iqbal, Saira Jabeen, Shawaal Zulfiqar, Tuba Hassan, Umm-e-Hani, Waheeda Akhtar.
Match starts at 8 p.m. IST.

Never imagined I would go past Mithali's tally: Smriti

Press Trust of India
DUBAI

Smriti Mandhana had to pinch herself after surpassing Mithali Raj to become the leading run-getter in women's internationals as she "never imagined" to go past the legendary Indian batter.

Smriti played a major part of her career under Mithali's captaincy. The former India captain was also her role model growing up.

History was created at the Dubai International Cricket Stadium on Thursday as the India vice-captain went past Mithali's tally of 10,868 international runs.

Smriti now has 10,880



Role model: Smriti says she looked up to Mithali, left, growing up. FILE PHOTO: VIVEK BENDRE

across the three formats.

"Till I was batting, I didn't know what record it was because I didn't know the exact runs. Mithali *di* has been a legend and a role model and we've all

grown up watching her.

"So, to go past her in the tally of runs, I definitely never imagined I would do that. I am happy there are two Indians in the top two," said Smriti.

Zverev survives; Khachanov knocks out Auger-Aliassime

US OPEN

Agence France-Presse
NEW YORK

Top-seeded Alexander Zverev kept his bid for a first US Open title on track with a gritty five-set victory over Quentin Halys, staying the course as a spate of upsets rocked the men's draw on Thursday.

A trio of former women's champions — Coco Gauff, Iga Swiatek and Naomi Osaka — booked third-round berths along with reigning Grand Slam champions Elena Rybakina and Mirra Andreeva.

But men's third seed Felix Auger-Aliassime tumbled out, along with sixth-seeded Alex de Minaur and 13th-seeded Lorenzo Musetti.

Zverev laboured until 2.15 a.m. on Friday at the Arthur Ashe Stadium to shake off 52nd-ranked Frenchman Halys 6-4, 4-6, 7-6(3), 6-7 (3), 6-3.

The four-hour 33-minute marathon followed his wild first-round five-setter against 89th-ranked Lorenzo Sonego that kept Zverev at it until shortly before 2 am on Wednesday.

While Zverev survived, Auger-Aliassime fell 6-7(5), 6-3, 6-2, 6-2 to 50th-ranked Karen Khachanov.

TOP RESULTS

Women: Third round: 16-Cirstea (Rou) bt 19-Paolini (Ita) 6-3, 6-3; 11-Kostyuk (Ukr) bt 18-Alexandrova 6-3, 6-2; 1-Sabalenska bt Rakhimova 6-3, 6-4; 3-Pegula (USA) bt 31-Fernandez (Can) 1-6, 6-4, 6-3.
Second round: 5-Andreeva bt Lys (Ger) 6-0, 6-2; 24-Potapova (Aut) bt Jeanjean (Fra) 6-4, 2-6, 6-3; 10-Anisimova (USA) bt Tagger (Aut) 6-3, 6-3, 6-1; 14-Jovic (USA) bt Jones (GBR) 6-4, 6-4; 17-Eala (Phi) bt Oliynykova (Ukr) 6-1, 6-4; 4-Gauff (USA) bt Badosa (Esp) 6-4, 7-6(5); Starodubtseva (Ukr) bt 32-Sakkari (Gre) 1-6, 7-6(4), 6-2; 2-Rybakina (Kaz) bt Maneiro (Esp) 6-2, 6-4.

Men: Second round: 1-Zverev (Ger) bt Halys (Fra) 6-4, 4-6, 7-6(3), 6-7(3), 6-3; 21-Darderi (Ita) bt Svrčina (Cze) 6-3, 6-7(5), 6-4, 6-4; Sweeny (Aus) bt 13-Musetti (Ita) 3-6, 6-1, 6-2, 6-2; 31-Bergs (Bel) bt de Jong (Ned) 7-5, 1-6, 6-2, 7-6(2); van de Zandschulp (Ned) bt 6-De Minaur (Aus) 6-4, 7-5, 6-2; Khachanov bt 3-Auger-Aliassime (Can) 6-7(5), 6-3, 6-2, 6-2; Bonzi (Fra) bt 32-Buse (Per) 6-2, 7-6(4), 6-0; 17-Mensik (Cze) bt Rodionov (Aut) 6-3, 3-6, 6-2, 6-3; 14-Tien (USA) bt Monfils (Fra) 6-3, 6-4, 6-3; 9-Fritz (USA) bt Bellucci (Ita) 6-0, 6-1, 6-1; 5-Cobolli (Ita) bt Schoolkate (Aus) 3-6, 6-3, 6-4, 7-5.



Seizing the opportunity: Khachanov pulled away relentlessly from Auger-Aliassime who struggled with his fitness. GETTY IMAGES

3-6, 6-1, 6-2, 6-2 to reach the third round of a Major for the first time.

Fourth-seeded Gauff,

the 2023 champion, thrilled the crowd with a 6-4, 7-6(5) win over Spain's Paula Badosa.

Battle of the brains in Garden City



Galaxy of stars: Carlsen, Anand and other players at the unveiling of the GCL trophy with league chairperson Peeyush Dubey and commissioner Gourav Rakshit. K. MURALI KUMAR

GLOBAL CHESS LEAGUE

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

No sport is driven by information technology as much as chess. No city in India is bigger for IT than Bengaluru. It is only apt then that the Global Chess League has come to the Garden City that houses the world's leading technology firms.

The world's leading chess players have assembled here for the fourth edition of the GCL — a joint venture of Tech Mahindra and world chess governing body FIDE — that opens at the Lalit Ashok here on Saturday. It is the second time that the planet's most glamorous chess league is being held in India. Season-3 was conducted in Mumbai after Dubai and London played hosts in the first two years.

A slew of innovations — such as no increment for the first 40 moves, four points for a win with black pieces, having both men and women in the teams and the practice of toss before a match — has made the GCL unique in interna-



Making a point: Carlsen is all ears as GCL commissioner Rakshit speaks. Anand looks on. K. MURALI KUMAR

tional chess. Little wonder, the world's best players have responded enthusiastically to the tournament.

The World No. 1 Magnus Carlsen is headlining the list of superstars in the mind sport. He had missed out in Mumbai, after playing in the first two seasons, but his team, Alpine Pipers, is the defending champion.

But only one player from last year — Anish Giri — has remained with the franchise for this season. Fabiano Caruana, Hou Yifan and R. Praggnanandhaa are absent. Alpine APL

Pipers, however, has added to the squad two top female stars, Koneru Humpy and Divya Deshmukh, the World Cup champion making her GCL debut.

Chess fans in Bengaluru would be able to see from close quarters many of their favourite players including Viswanathan Anand (PBG Alaskan Knights), Alireza Firouzja (Triveni Continental Kings), Javokhir Sindarov (Fyers American Gambits), Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (CheQ Mumbai Masters) and Ian Nepomniachtchi (Ganges Grandmasters).

Carlsen glad to be back at the GCL after a break

P.K. Ajith Kumar
BENGALURU

Chess is finding newer fans. Five-time World champion Magnus Carlsen feels that has been the case for the last five or six years across the world.

"We are still finding different ways to present chess," said the Norwegian on the eve of the Global Chess League, which kicks off here on Saturday.

"For me it is interesting to be part of these innovative events (such as the GCL and the Total Chess World Championship Tour). There is a lot of enthusiasm to present chess in the best way possible."

Carlsen is glad to be back at the GCL after a year's interval. "We had a couple of really frustrating years for the team (Alpine Pipers) when I was playing," he said. "And then when I was away, the team won the title. So, this time I am just trying to do my best to not do any worse than last year."

Unlike Carlsen, Viswanathan Anand, also a five-time World champion, is playing for a new team this year — PBG Alaskan Knights. "Every year you have to come with a positive attitude," he said. "We have a great team...and my role is just that of a player (and not a mentor)."

Jovakhir Sindarov, who will be challenging D. Gukesh for the World title later this year, said he wasn't thinking about that match at the moment. "I have enjoyed playing in every season of the GCL," he said. "I am excited that I will be



Divya Deshmukh. K. MURALI KUMAR

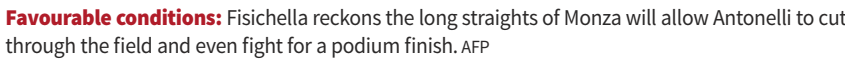
playing on the first board this year and I will try my best to help my team (Fyers American Gambits) win the tournament."

Among the biggest attractions of the league is the Turkish prodigy Yagiz Kaan Erdogmus. He is making his GCL debut and is part of Alaskan Knights.

Amazing experience
"It is going to be an amazing experience for me to play along with Vishy (Anand) and Arjun (Erigaisi)," he said.

Like him, Divya Deshmukh is also playing at the GCL for the first time. And she is looking forward to the experience of playing without increment though she is also a bit wary of it. "I would love to flag some of my opponents (in the time scramble)," said the Women's World Cup winner.

The GCL's chairman Peeyush Dubey said the GCL proved chess could also be a festival. "And we have support from some of the biggest companies in the world," he said.



The former three-time GP winner says the Mercedes sensation has a better feeling with the car this season and can go far

A ND-NDE